

City lumbers to avoid fire-prone trees

By [DANIEL LANGHORNE](#)

2013-05-20 07:22:12

The City Council is looking to root out the city's practice of planting species that are deemed potential fire hazards by fire officials.

The City Council took the first step last week by voting for a moratorium on city staff planting pine trees within the city limits. The Orange County Fire Authority put pine trees on a list of undesirable species that should not be used in fire prone areas.

"There's no reason to continue a bad practice," said Councilman John Anderson, who proposed the pine tree ban. "To me it's one of the clearest issues we've faced in a long time."

Kris Concepcion, division chief for the Orange County Fire Authority, said fire officials learned a lot of lessons about troublesome landscaping from the 2008 Freeway Complex Fire. He said there are oils inside pine trees that make them more susceptible to fire and can be dangerous if they are planted close to homes and not maintained.

The city will do a comprehensive review of its landscaping palette. This partly comes from damage that palm trees also did during the fire. If the palm fronds aren't properly trimmed they can dry out and catch fire and embers carried by the wind can collect in the tree's crown, Concepcion said.

The City Council will receive an update on changes to city landscaping on May 21.

City staff will notify developers currently building and those in plan check to not use pine trees in their landscaping, said Mark Stowell, director of public works. Stowell added that the city cannot prevent someone from planting a pine tree on private property, but it is their responsibility to limit the risk of fire to their home and their neighbors' homes.

Councilman Gene Hernandez was the lone opposing vote, although he supports the idea behind the ban. He said he wanted to give developers clear direction on alternatives to pine tree. He was also concerned that it would look awkward to start planting a different species next to long stretches of pines that already line some streets.

"I just want a systematic approach so we do it the right way," he said.

Dr. Jack Kennis, a local property rights activist, saw the council's decision as a victory for the community.

Besides the safety issue, Kennis has been vocal at council meetings that the pine trees obstruct views and bring down people's home values.

Concepcion emphasized to the council that residents can invite fire authority employees to do a risk assessment of the landscaping around their home. Fire officials recommend residents visit readyssetgooc.org and look under documents to see a list of dos and don'ts when landscaping yards.

Contact the writer: [714-704-3704](tel:714-704-3704) or dlanghorne@ocregister.com